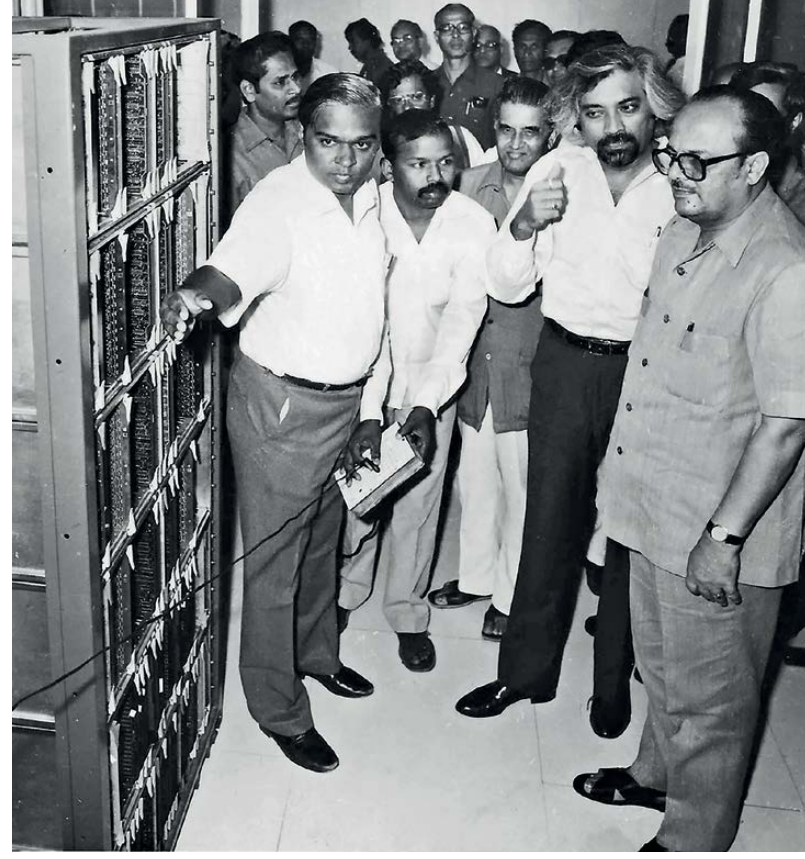
SIGNALLING GROWTH

- Reliance Jio leads as the world's largest mobile data carrier
- Mobile phones have catalysed the rise of UPI and digital payments
- The underprivileged have got access to social schemes and benefits
- C-DOT is working with Indian innovators to build 4G/5G/6G equipment of global standards
- Domestic factories produce 97% of India's total handset demand, export 30% of products

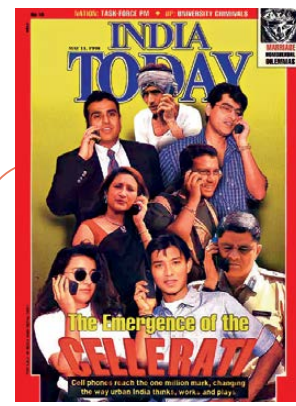


SOWING THE SEEDS
Sam Pitroda and Arjun Singh at a rural telephone exchange developed by C-DOT, 1987

and the country began embracing GSM technology. Towers sprang up across urban centres to support this rapidly growing network. The WLL-CDMA technology arrived later, championed by companies like Tata and Reliance Communications. But GSM's global compatibility cemented its dominance. "Airtel has been at the forefront of India's telecom revolution," said Sunil Bharti Mittal, chairman, Bharti Airtel, while addressing the World Telecommunication Standardization Assembly in October 2024. "It has stood the test of time, it has seen the journey right from 2G to where we are in India today, creating a digital revolution that the world is seeing." While Airtel still remains a dominant player, Reliance Jio, established in 2016, is now not just India's but also the world's largest mobile data carrier.

But back then, it was still a time when obtaining a fixed-line connection meant queuing up for weeks. Mobile phones, though rare, were revolutionary. Their rise quickly overshadowed pagers, which had briefly gained traction. Today, the mobile phone has evolved from a luxury item to a lifeline for nearly 1.2 billion subscribers. India, which now has the world's second-largest mobile network, offers among the most affordable data rates globally, at just $0.16 (Rs 13.5) per GB. The sector's focus on affordability and teledensity—over 90 per cent now—has empowered even rural populations, making mobile phones critical tools for bridging socio-economic gaps.

From making UPI payments to accessing social media and OTT platforms, everything can be done on a handheld device. The government has leveraged this technology to deepen its social outreach, employing the 'JAM' trinity—Jan Dhan bank accounts, Aadhaar IDs, and mobile phones—to deliver targeted welfare benefits. Mobile manufacturing has also surged, with local factories meeting 97 per cent of the domestic handset demand. The journey that began in 1995 with a single call now defines a connected India, bridging divides and reshaping aspirations. ■



FROM THE ARCHIVES
May 11, 1998

Cover Story
The Emergence of the Cellerati

Only into the third year of its introduction in the metros, and just a few months in other cities, the cell phone is already an integral part of the urban landscape...cobbling up a new class of the "cellerati".

With the number of mobile phones touching a million in the April-June quarter...the cell phone era has dawned.

-Sumit Mitra